

FAVA BEANS *Vicia faba*

Eat homegrown favas, also known as broad beans, as soon as possible after harvesting, since this is when they are at their sweetest and most delicious, beating any store-bought version hands down. Or, try picking while pods are very young and tender and cooking them whole or eating in salads. Dwarf varieties can be grown in containers on a patio or in small gardens and their beautifully scented flowers will attract bees.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
SOW/PLANT				
HARVEST				

SOWING

Dig in plenty of well-rotted manure or compost in the fall before sowing—fava beans will probably not need any extra fertilizer, since nodules on their roots fix and store nitrogen in the soil. They prefer well-drained, fertile soil, and taller varieties will appreciate some shelter. Plant where root crops have previously grown.

Seed can be sown directly in the ground and protected from frost, if necessary, or it can be sown in pots and transplanted later. Sow at a depth of 2 in (5 cm), leaving 6 in (15 cm) between plants and 24 in (60 cm) between rows. In warm-winter areas, favas can be fall-sown; otherwise, spring seeding will produce a summer harvest.



Create deep planting holes with a dibber.

CROP CARE

Construct supports for taller varieties using bamboo canes. Dwarf varieties may need some support or earthing up as they develop and become top-heavy. Use sticks or canes to prevent dwarf varieties from trailing on the ground, where they will be at greater risk from pests. Mulch well around plants and ensure that they are kept well-watered.